

SECULAR OUTREACH
KCR at an *iftar* party organised by the Telangana government at a stadium in Hyderabad, April 30

THE BIG THREAT TO THE TRS'S POLITICAL LONGEVITY IS SEEN TO BE THE BJP. HOW KCR MEETS THAT CHALLENGE WILL DETERMINE WHEN HE PASSES ON THE MANTLE TO SON KTR

The latest CAG report also claims Telangana has been persistently trailing behind other states in expenditure on education and health, and that the gap is increasing. Indeed, the outlay for education in the budget shrank from 10.9 per cent in 2014-15 to a paltry 6.2 per cent for 2022-23. The allocation for health, however, saw an unprecedented rise in the budget for 2022-23—Rs 11,237 crore was earmarked, almost double the amount allocated in the previous budget.

CHANGE OF GUARD?

One major challenge for KCR lies in choosing the right time to announce his son KTR, who already holds several key portfolios, as his successor. Considering the growing anti-incumbency in the state, this change of guard is likely to be put on hold while the father-son duo awaits the outcome of the 2023 election. And of course, a national role for the father cannot be made to materialise purely on the basis of desire. There are also organisational issues: the party is beset with infighting in several districts. There are many instances of strained relations between ministers and MLAs, most visibly in constituencies where the latter were elected on a Congress ticket and then switched loyalties to the TRS. KCR had ensured that the defectors were not disqualified.

Making up for the deficit in goodwill and trust is a daunting task. For this, the TRS has to bank on its biggest strength—its pioneering schemes like Rythu Bandhu and Dalit Bandhu, which have been accepted by other states and even the Centre as replicable models. The Union government awards that Telangana has been winning since 2015, particularly in rural development, are testimony to the TRS government's efforts to ensure overall development. Be it Gandagi Mukt Bharat, Saansad Adarsh Gram Yojana, Swachh Survekshan or other such rankings, many rural bodies from Telangana feature in the lists. KCR's brainchild, the Palle Pragathi (village development) programme, gave an impetus to these measures, and a key factor for the success has been its effective implementation across the state. "Appointing additional collectors for local bodies was a game-changer. No other state has done it," says Sandeep K. Sultania, the state's rural development secretary.

Anticipating that KCR may opt for an early poll, the Opposition is already in battle mode. While state Congress president A. Revanth Reddy, a trenchant critic of KCR and KTR, is hosting a farmers' rally on May 6 in Warangal, where Rahul is expected to speak, BJP state chief Bandi Sanjay is leading a Praja Sangrama Yatra, a walkathon covering the entire state. When the rhetoric starts flowing from the other side, the challenge of beating anti-incumbency after two terms in office may start looking a bit more daunting for KCR. He will have to bank on his communication skills, with support from I-PAC, to convince Telangana to give him another chance. An ardent admirer of Telugu actor-turned-CM Nandamuri Taraka Rama Rao a.k.a. NTR, after whom he named his son KTR, the TRS chief will need all the skills and panache of the late showman to pull this off. ■